



The Afar Depression

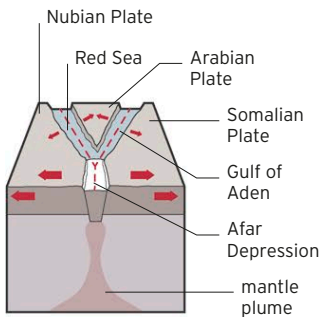
One of the hottest and driest places on Earth, a region of volcanoes, hot springs, and salt lakes

Also called the Afar Triangle due to its shape, the Afar Depression is a low-lying region touching Ethiopia, Eritrea, and Djibouti. It is an area where Earth is thought to be rifting apart with thinning and stretching of the crust above an upwelling plume of hot mantle rocks. The presence of the magma underground is apparent in the form of many volcanoes at the surface, including a massive shield volcano (a broad volcano with shallow slopes), Erta Ale, which has a permanent lava lake. Partly because much of it lies below sea level, the Afar Depression is one of the hottest places on Earth.

▽ **COLORFUL CRATERS**
These hot springs, with salt and sulfur deposits, lie 150 ft (45 m) below sea level at Dallol in the northern part of the Afar region.

THE AFAR TRIPLE JUNCTION

The Afar Triple Junction is a spot on Earth's surface where the Arabian Plate and two parts of the African Plate—the Nubian and Somalian Plates—are slowly separating. Projecting from this site are three arms, or rifts (down-faulted sections of crust). Two are occupied by the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden. The northern part of the third arm is the Afar Depression.



◁ **NORTHERN SURVIVOR**
The only surviving primate in Africa north of the Sahara Desert, the Barbary macaque has adapted to living in the rocky cliffs and high-altitude oak and cedar forests of the Atlas range.